

Crucial Conversations®

Tools for Talking when Stakes are High

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The Big “So What”

Our daily interactions can hold pivotal moments, with outcomes that affect the quality of our relationships, careers and life. **This book helps us to identify and effectively conduct “crucial conversations”, so we can overcome difficult or sensitive issues, to improve results and achieve our desired outcomes.**



Introduction

The authors started with the goal to find out what made some people more effective than others. They discovered that **the most outstanding leaders are able to influence the outcomes of difficult but vital conversations, without offending others.** By following these leaders, observing how they handled such conversations, developing and testing theories and tools, the authors developed the tips in this book.

In this summary, we will provide an overview of the **7 key principles and associated skills of crucial conversations.** For more detailed tips, powerful examples and exercises, do refer to the book.

**Crucial conversations –
what they are, and why they’re crucial**



Crucial conversations have **3 key components: high stakes, differing views, and strong emotions.** They may not involve **big issues, but their outcomes can affect the quality of our lives.** For example, an innocent remark to your neighbour about their late night (noisy) parties can unexpectedly degenerate into a shouting match; overnight, your two families end up in a “cold war”, and both sides are unhappy.

KEY QUOTES

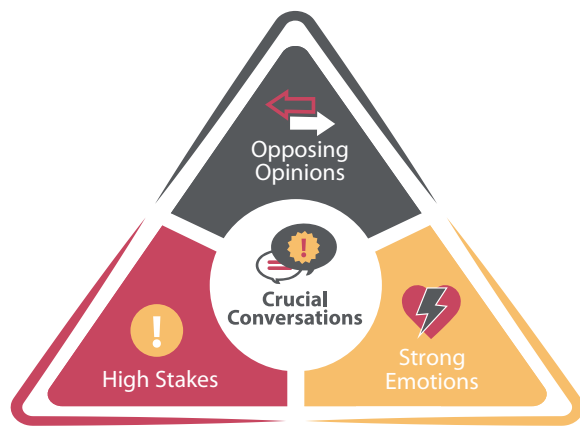
“The root cause of many – if not most – human problems lies in how people behave when others disagree with them about high-stakes, emotional issues.”

“The single biggest problem in communication is the illusion that it has taken place.”
- George Bernard Shaw

“The crucial conversations we’re referring to are interactions that happen to everyone. They’re the day-to-day conversations that affect your life.”

“What makes each of these conversations crucial...is that the results could have a huge impact on the quality of your life.”

“If you know how to handle crucial conversations, you can effectively hold tough conversations about virtually any topic.”



Unfortunately, we are usually at our worst performance when faced with crucial conversations – because the issues are important (and often personal) to us, our emotions take over (pushing logic aside), and things start to spiral downwards.



The 7 Principles to Mastering Crucial Conversation

The Importance of Dialogues



When we enter a conversation, we bring along our beliefs, experiences, emotions, and perspectives – these jointly form our “pool of meaning”. An effective dialogue involves 2 or more people exchanging meaning freely between them. For this to happen, we must make it safe for people to contribute their meaning to a common pool – that way, everyone can get a more complete picture of varying perspectives and ideas, build on them and arrive at a more informed decision, with greater understanding and ownership.

On the other hand, conflict arises when people hold different opinions and pools of meaning. Instead of a free and constructive exchange, people may become:

- **Silent and withdrawn.** They withhold their opinions for fear of confrontation, offending others or sounding stupid; or
- **Violent and aggressive.** They force their opinion on others, directly or indirectly (e.g. using sarcastic remarks, putting down others, or using authority to impose their views).

We'll now zoom in on how to identify crucial conversations, and how to master the skills to handle them.

KEY QUOTES

“People who routinely hold crucial conversations and hold them well are able to express controversial and even risky opinions in a way that gets heard.”

“The more important the discussion, the less likely we are to be on our best behaviour.”

“When it comes to risky, controversial, and emotional conversations, skilled people find a way to get all relevant information (from themselves and others) out into the open.”

“Since the meaning is shared, people willingly act on whatever decisions they make – with both unity and conviction.”

“When people purposefully withhold meaning from one another, individually smart people can do collectively stupid things.”

“It's the most important set of skills you'll ever master... create conditions in yourself and others that will make dialogue the path of least resistance.”



1. Start with Heart (Get the Right Focus)

It's easy to give in to our emotional impulses, or to choose between 2 poor choices. The first step is to hence get your heart right.

Know and Focus on What you Truly Want



Imagine this: You've just explained to your team how critical it is to complete the current project on schedule, and urged everyone to complete their assigned tasks by the week. One of your staff points out that 2 days ago, you agreed defer a vital input by another department, which caused a delay to your team's output. You feel offended by this open challenge, and are tempted to dismiss the comment or to retort with a sarcastic remark.

This is common problem in crucial conversations - **When emotions take over, we lose sight of our original goals, and become distracted by one of these less noble goals:**

- **Winning** the argument or proving ourselves rights;
- **Punishing** the other person for making us feel embarrassed, disrespected, hurt; and/or
- **Avoiding** conflict.

First, **get clear on your objectives. Break down your goals into 3 parts** – what you *really* want for (a) yourself, (b) others and (c) the relationship.

Then, **when faced with situations like the one above, take a step back:**

- **Examine if your motives have shifted** (e.g. if you're now focused on defending your ego rather than completing the project on schedule). Consider what your actions would say about your true motives, if you were looking at them as a third party.
- Then, **re-focus** and consider what you should do to achieve your real goals.

KEY QUOTES

"If you can't get yourself right, you'll have a hard time getting your dialogue right."

"When you name the game, you can stop playing it."

Refuse the Fool's Choice



Often, we mistakenly think there are only two options (e.g. talk to your spouse about her bad habit and make her unhappy, or avoid the topic altogether). During crucial conversations, we feel threatened, our brain shuts down, and we're even more likely to settle for the Fool's Choice.

The better approach is to realize that the options are not mutually-exclusive. It is possible to voice your concerns, while maintaining respect or a positive relationship. **Get clear on what you truly want, what you truly don't want, and figure out how to achieve both objectives.** Use the word "and" to frame your question, e.g. "How can I talk to my spouse about her bad habit *and* not make her unhappy?", or "How can I request for flexible work arrangements *and* keep my promotion?"



2. Learn to Look (Know when it's unsafe)

Most people focus only on the content (e.g. words) of a discussion, but neglect the more subtle conditions (e.g. feelings, tones). **Become aware when a dialogue is breaking down, so you can bring it back on track.** Here are some conditions to look out for:



Conversation Cues: Look for signs that a conversation has shifted from a normal one to a crucial one. The cues can be *physical* (e.g. tightening of chest, clenching of fists), *emotional* (e.g. feelings of fear, hurt, anger) or *behavioural* (e.g. finger pointing, raised voices).



Loss of safety: When people feel safe, they tend to share more freely. When they feel insecure, they retreat, become more defensive, and can be blind to logic. Usually, they'll either resort to silence or violence:

- Silence could manifest as *avoidance* (e.g. changing the subject, evading an answer), *masking* (e.g. using indirect references or sarcasm), or *withdrawal* (e.g. leaving the dialogue);

KEY QUOTES

"The mistake most of us make in our crucial conversations is we believe we have to choose between telling the truth and keeping a friend."

"When our brain isn't functioning well, we resist complexity. We adore the ease of simply choosing between attacking or hiding."

"The sooner you notice you're not in dialogue, the easier it is to get back and the lower the costs."

- Violence could show up as *controlling* (e.g. exaggerating facts), using *labels* (like stupid or evil) to discredit ideas or people, or *attacking* (threatening or belittling others).



Know your personal cues: It's harder to observe yourself than others. Use the survey in the book to learn what reactions you're most prone to under stress, so you can look out for them.



3. Make it Safe (Facilitate an Open Dialogue)

Once you see signs that you or others feel unsafe, **the best approach is to step out of the current conversation, restore safety, then resume the dialogue.** With a safe environment, you can once again talk things through openly.

Identify What's at Risk



There are 2 key conditions required for a safe dialogue:



Mutual Purpose. To *start* a dialogue, people must believe that you care about them and their goals (rather than hold malicious intent). Have everyone clarify their goals using the "Start with Heart" questions, then identify a common goal – this sets a positive context for the dialogue.



Mutual Respect. Respect is essential to sustain or *continue* the dialogue. Once people feel that they're being disrespected, they shift their focus away from the discussion to protecting their pride. To restore safety, you need to stay connected, by empathizing with others or by focusing on areas of similarities (rather than differences).

3 Approaches for Restoring Safety



Once you have stepped out of the conversation, choose the right approach for your situation:



Apologize. If you've caused someone pain due to your **mistake, apologize first.** If this brings back a safe space, you can proceed to explain what happened; if it doesn't, move on to the other methods below.

KEY QUOTES

"Mutual Purpose means that others perceive that you're working toward a common outcome in the conversation, that you care about their goals, interests and values. And vice versa."

"Respect is like air. As long as it's present, nobody thinks about it. But if you take it away, it's all that people can think about."

"To offer a sincere apology, your motives have to change. You have to give up saving face, being right, or winning in order to focus on what you really want."



Use contrasting. If there has been a misunderstanding (not due to your fault), use this method to address it. Start by addressing the others' concerns (e.g. "I didn't mean to give you the impression that I don't value your suggestions."), then *affirm* your respect or clarify your true objectives (e.g. "I do appreciate the innovative and constructive ideas that you've been offering."). Unlike an apology, contrasting is about putting things in perspective, so you can prevent further breakdown in the dialogue, or reduce the pain from a misunderstanding.



Develop Mutual Purpose. If you and your partner(s) have different or even opposing goals, you'll need to first develop a **common objective**, before you can resume an effective dialogue. Use the "CRIB" approach to achieve this:

- o Commit to find a Mutual Purpose: Make a sincere, unilateral commitment to stick to the conversation until you can find a solution to your mutual goals, e.g. "It appears we have different views on this issue, but I'm committed to stick to our discussion until we find an outcome that meets both our goals."
- o Recognize our Purpose is different from our Approach: What we want is often not the same as what we say to get it. Ask people *why* they are making their request, to understand the underlying goal. By clearly identifying the end goal that both parties want, you can step away from your original approach to find new alternatives.
- o Inv_ent a Mutual Purpose. If your goal can't be achieved except at the other person's expense (or vice versa), one option is to rise above the short-term goals and identify a broader, more inspiring common goal.
- o Brainstorm new approaches, focusing on solutions that can achieve both parties' goals.

It's hard to apply these skills in the midst of an emotionally-charged conversation. **The key is to learn the skills before crucial conversations take place.** The improvements may be incremental, but any progress can bring positive results, and they add up over time.

KEY QUOTES

"When it comes to these high-stakes conversations, a little progress can produce a lot of benefit."



4. Master your Stories (Stay in Constructive Dialogue)

Managing your emotions will help you to master crucial conversations, and stay in dialogue despite negative feelings.

Understand the “Path to Action”



First, let's look at why people react emotionally, and why the same circumstances may trigger different responses in different people.

When we see or hear something, we create a story about why it happens, and decide if it's good or bad – these affect how we feel, which affects how we act. The authors call this the “Path to Action”:



Imagine you're in the middle of a meeting. You see a colleague lean over and whisper something to another colleague; both of them snigger and one of them glances at you. You tell yourself angrily that they must be gossiping about you, and make a mental note to confront them later. Such stories may be conjured so quickly that you feel upset without realizing the underlying story you've created.

There are typically 3 types of stories that we tell ourselves:

- **Victim plot:** We present ourselves as the victims and ignore how we may have contributed to the problem or situation.
- **Villain plot:** We present the other party as a total villain (e.g. idiot, maniac, slave-driver) and ignore their positive or humane side.
- **Helpless plot:** We present ourselves as having no choice but to do what we did.

We tell such stories because they allow us to shirk responsibility and justify our actions (which we may silently acknowledge is undesirable). However, **we do have a part to play in most unhappy situations:**

- No one can make us upset. Our feelings are a result of how we react to others, *so we make ourselves upset.*

KEY QUOTES

“If we take control of our stories, they won't control us.”

“‘Clever stories’...allow us to feel good about behaving badly even while achieving abysmal results.”

- Once we're upset, our emotions prompt our actions (e.g. confronting our colleagues), and also prompt others' response.

Know and Master your Stories



To break the cycle, the best way is to:



Retrace your steps. Pause what you're doing and retrace your "Path to Action" in reverse order:

- o Take note of how you are acting (e.g. if you're being withdrawn or aggressive);
- o Identify the feelings behind those actions;
- o Examine the story that's creating those feelings; and
- o Check if the story is based on real facts (which can be measured and verified), or if there could be alternative explanations.

The book also includes several examples and additional tips, such as "hot words" to listen for, and how to test your assumptions.



Tell the remaining story. Fill in the missing details/perspectives of your stories to make them constructive. Specifically:

- o Convert victims to actors: Be aware of your role in the situation and take responsibility for the mistakes you may have made.
- o Convert villains to humans: View others through the lens of empathy, to see their positive side and the reasons for their behaviours (which are often not malicious).
- o Convert the helpless to the able: Revisit the "Start with Heart questions", and use the "and technique" in Step 1, to identify what you could do to achieve your desired results.



5. State your Path (Share your views persuasively)

How do you convey something bad or controversial, yet maintain a positive, respectful tone? Here are **5 STATE skills to share your views without offending others**:

KEY QUOTES

"Separate fact from story by focusing on behaviour."

"If the '60 Minutes' camera crew replayed this scene on national television, how would you look? What would they tell about your behaviour?"

"By asking what role you've played...you become aware of how you've minimized your own mistakes while you've exaggerated the role of others."

"The best at dialogue...are both completely frank and completely respectful."



Share the Facts. Start by sharing what you saw or heard, rather than your story. For example, rather than saying “you’ve been lying to me”, it’s safer to start with “you said you didn’t know Esther, but I just saw a photo of you two together.”



Tell your Story. Share your story and feelings, using contrasting to minimize misunderstanding, and watching for signs that people feel unsafe.



Ask for Others’ Paths. Encourage others to share their own facts, stories and feelings, and be open-minded to alternative views.



Talk Tentatively. Present your stories as hypotheses rather than facts. Use phrases like “I wasn’t sure if...”, or “I was wondering if...”, rather than “The point is...”, “My view is...”.



Encourage Testing. When others feel unsafe, they will be reluctant to share their honest views, stories or feelings. Encourage testing by asking others (respectfully) to disprove your story.

As you apply these skills, keep looking for signs of silence or violence. Once you spot such signs that the other person feels unsafe, examine if you’re also behaving that way. Step back, tone down, and restore safety. **Remember that your views are not the only valid ones, and forcing your way through will only cause a downward spiral.**



6. Explore Others’ Path (Be a Good Listener)

When you notice signs (silence or aggression) that safety has been breached, how do you proceed? **Besides apologizing, using contrasting and finding mutual purpose, we must be ready to listen.** To do this, we must be:

- **Sincere.** Be genuinely interested in others’ views;

KEY QUOTES

“When we feel the need to push our ideas on others, it’s generally because we believe we’re right and everyone else is wrong.”

“The reason we should speak tentatively is because we, indeed, are not certain that our opinions represent absolute truth or our understanding of the facts is complete and perfect.”

“The harder we try and the more forceful and nasty our tactics, the greater resistance we create, the worse the results and the more battered our relationships.”

- **Curious.** When others become silent or violent, or share their stories and feelings, it's easy to mirror them and get dragged into our own stories. Instead, be curious about why they would react that way; and
- **Patient.** Emotions tend to linger on even after thoughts have shifted. Hence, someone may still feel emotionally unsafe even if they've logically accept they're safe.

Encourage Others to Share their Views



By the time conversations turn crucial, they are already moving through the Path to Action. **It's vital to manage our own emotions, and focus on helping others to retrace their path – our goal is to find the source and facts behind the stories and feelings.**

To do so, use these **4 listening tools (AMPP)**:



Ask. Take the initiative by sincerely inviting them to share, e.g. "Please help me to understand what's going on", "I'd really like to know what you think about this."



Mirror. Confirm feelings by mirroring what you see, e.g. "You say you're fine, but you seem really tense."



Paraphrase. Summarize or rephrase the message in your own words, to make sure you've understood it correctly



Prime. As a last resort, if you sense that the other party is still withholding, try making a best-guess of what their story may be, then prime it e.g. "Are you thinking that this innovation is too risky?"

Even if you feel that the other person's view may not be right, remember to keep an open mind – the goal is to keep the dialogue going to reach a mutually-satisfactory resolution.

Minimize unnecessary disagreements



Remember the **ABC** of effective dialogues:

KEY QUOTES

"At the very moment when most people become furious, we need to become curious. Rather than respond in kind, we need to wonder what's behind the ruckus."

"If we don't get at the source of their feelings, we'll end up suffering the effects of the feelings."

"Priming is an act of good faith, taking risks, becoming vulnerable, and building safety in hopes that others will share their meaning."

"Understanding doesn't equate with agreement. Sensitivity does equate to acquiescence."

- **Agree.** When you've secured a broad agreement, don't allow the small details to turn an agreement into an argument (e.g. you've decided to proceed on a project, but can't agree on the start date).
- **Build.** If you're in broad agreement but lack specific information, reinforce the agreement, then focus on filling the missing gaps.
- **Compare.** When you have differing views, compare the stories to identify and understand the differences, rather than dismiss either story as "wrong".

KEY QUOTES



7. Move to Action (Convert dialogue to results)

An effective dialogue allows us to develop shared meaning and shared purpose. However, reaching an agreement does not guarantee action and results, e.g. you may have agreed to set up an inter-departmental taskforce, but the execution details may not have been decided.

Make Specific Decisions

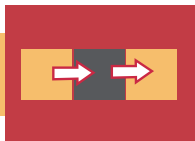


The authors share 4 decision-making methods you can choose from:

- **Command:** This works well when decisions are necessitated by external factors like customer or industry demands, or when the stakes are too low for detailed discussions.
- **Consult:** This involves soliciting inputs, views or options from others before making a decision.
- **Vote:** This is great for choosing between several good options.
- **Consensus:** This can be tedious and frustrating, and should only be used for complex issues, and/or when it's vital to secure all stakeholders' support.

In choosing between these 4 methods, consider who really cares to be involved, who has the know-how for sound decisions, who must support or cooperate for the decision to work, and how many people must be involved (proportionate to the importance of the issue).

Ensure Follow-up



Once a decision has been made, **ensure closure** by (a) clearly specifying who to do what by when, and (b) establishing clear follow-up and accountability.



Other Details in the Book to Look Out For

The book includes many useful case studies to illustrate crucial conversations at work at home and in the workplace, and how to apply the skills and tips to achieve your desired outcomes. There are also several useful exercises for you to practice handling difficult situations, a “Style Under Stress” survey and an entire chapter dedicated to examples of difficult or sensitive conversations. Some examples include: dealing with an overly-sensitive spouse, blatant disrespect, or under-performing teammates. For additional resources, videos and other useful materials, do get a copy of the book or go to www.CrucialConversations.com/.

KEY QUOTES

“If you want people to feel accountable, you must give them an opportunity to account.”